dinipur district, and are a face-saver in the backyard of BJP leader and the face of the party's 2024 campaign, Suvendu Adhikari. Key BJP candidates like Nisith Pramanik and Subhas Sarkar, the Union ministers of state for home and education respectively, and former BJP state president Dilip Ghosh were defeated. The BJP's vote share fell from 40.6 per cent in 2019 to 38.7 per cent this time. Though the Left-Congress combine did not do well—their only success was a win for Congress's Isha Khan Chowdhury from Malda Dakshin—their combined vote share of 10.6 per cent ate into the BJP share. However, framing of the Citizenship Amendment Act rules helped the BJP retain the Matua-dominated Bongaon and Ranaghat seat, but by diminished margins.

The TMC's showing will give Mamata the upper hand in the battle of perception for the 2026 assembly polls. Sandeshkhali barely had an impact this election

While she taunted Modi for "losing his magic and credibility" and called for his resignation along with that of Union home minister Amit Shah, Mamata made common cause with INDIA or the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance. However, she took a dig at the Congress and justified her decision to go it alone in the polls. "I have texted Rahul congratulating him. They haven't contacted us yet, but it doesn't matter if they do or don't. I had said that they will not win more than two (seats). What happened?" she asked, adding that she will continue to support the alliance.

TMC'S WINNING STRATEGY

While the TMC can gloat over their victory, it looked implausible a year back. A slew of alleged corruption cases—the coal scam, the cattle smuggling scam and the especially damaging teachers' recruitment scam—had battered the party, even as new charges like the ration scam embarrassed it even more. To reinstate people's faith, Abhishek undertook a 60-day statewide yatra in 2023, during which he realised that the non-payment of funds under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) and PM Awas Yojana-Grameen (PMAY-G) had angered people. He thus evolved a cunning strategy—in meeting after meeting, he played on that disgruntlement, juxtaposing the TMC's welfare schemes with how the BJP-led Centre—"anti-Bengal outsiders"—had deprived the state. At a huge rally in Kolkata on March 10, Abhishek encapsulated it all in a slogan: *Jonogoner Gorjon, Bangla Birodhider Bisorjon* (Roar of the people...will immerse anti-Bengal people).

However, what paid dividends many times over for the TMC is the direct benefit transfer scheme for women—Lakshmir Bhandar. The monthly honorarium paid to women was increased to Rs 1,000 (from Rs 500) for general categories and to Rs 1,200 (from Rs 1,000) for scheduled groups ahead of the polls. With over 20 million beneficiaries, its impact has been far-reaching. Bengal has over 37.3 million women voters (as compared to 38.3 million males) and till the sixth phase of polls, 81.22 per cent of them exercised their franchise. In every rally, Mamata and Abhishek said that the BJP, if voted to power, would stop the scheme. "It successfully instilled a sense of fear among women, even though Lakshmir Bhandar is a state scheme and isn't related to who comes to power in Delhi," says political analyst Biswajit Bhattacharya.

Despite the BJP targeting the TMC over corruption, it is evident that people are willing to disregard it and still believe in Mamata. "Anti-incumbency against Modi triggered by unemployment, inflation and a fear that he might change the Constitution...also played on the voters' minds," adds Bhattacharya.

THE ROAD TO 2026

Meanwhile, the BJP appears to have been weighed down by drawbacks of poor organisation and candidate selection. Its biggest bet, the charge of atrocities against women by TMC men in Sandeshkhali, turned out to be a dud. In fact, the sting videos that the TMC released, accusing Adhikari and the BJP of engineering the protests, appears to have worked better. The TMC won the Basirhat seat, under which Sandeshkhali falls, by a margin of 333,547 votes. Adhikari, who got a free hand in selecting BJP candidates, blamed "electoral malpractices" and "violence by the TMC" to explain the defeat. "I accept the mandate of the people and thank them for polling one per cent more votes than 2021 in our favour and giving us a lead in close to 100 assembly seats," he said, trying to salvage something from the ruins. Much of the blame for the BJP's defeat shall have to be borne by Adhikari, who surely faces a question mark over his future.

On June 7, the state BJP leadership met the party high command to dissect the reasons behind this poor showing. The TMC, on the other hand, will now have an upper hand in the battle of perceptions before the crucial assembly election of 2026. This election has proven that voters would rally behind it even amidst towering allegations of corruption. Even so, the TMC leadership will need to regularly review the performances of their public representatives for the next two years to deny the Opposition a chance to build a damaging narrative. ■